7.8 The Pilis Mountains and the Szentendre Island Programme, Hungary

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Introduction

This case-study provides a methodological proposal for the process of assessing archaeological significance, considering not only the academic importance and the protection of archaeological sites, but also the social implications of cultural heritage with the help of a community archaeology pilot project. Building on earlier developments, from the 1960s a major archaeological programme, the Archaeological Topography of Hungary introduced a complex system for mapping and interpreting sites. This project delivered continuous methodological development, including survey techniques, documentation, and interpretation of sites. However, the assessment of significance in the context of mapped and identified archaeological sites cannot be seen in a similar way in these processes. Various factors were taken into consideration in the context of academic research, such as the importance of finds from a site, or standing monuments at a site, but no standard system has developed for these aspects. In addition, there is no transparent protocol in the evaluation system (see section 7.7 for outline of Hungarian legal system) which would be desirable both for academic research, and in the context of contract archaeology.

To date, Hungarian archaeology has not applied any prioritisation in its excavation strategy during development led or contract archaeology projects. The principle applies that everything must be explored. Investors are bound by law to finance the excavation of affected sites, more precisely the part of the site affected by the building operations. A recent legislation introduced the principle of covering archaeological sites of less importance. However, the assessment of the importance depends on the actual and highly variable circumstances and is not based on factual information. A generally applied and well-structured system is highly needed, not only to determine the fate of sites impacted by development, but also for scientific reasons. The system should be designed to help scholars in deciding on the extent and methodology of their excavations, and also the arrangements applied after the accomplishment of the fieldwork: conservation of unearthed elements, covering the walls, or presentation of the results on-site.

In Hungary, museums with archaeological collections and excavation rights operating under regional competences have the closest connection with archaeological sites. New information is regularly added to the museum repositories and frequently provided to investors for developments or to central research institutes for their research projects. Therefore, it is essential to keep the information on the extent, intensity, or importance of sites up to date. Collecting, storing, and sharing data, interpreting archaeological heritage is an increasingly complex responsibility. Supervision of archaeological sites is the task of the cultural heritage authority (government office), however, neither museums, nor the authority have enough resources for this. At the same time, the growing importance of community archaeology in Hungary offers now new possibilities to meet these challenges.

The scheme of the project presented here has been developed based on the Hungarian legal system, the daily practice of a museum with a strong programme in community archaeology, and with the goal to develop a standardized, but flexible system, which can be followed by similar organisations. The new system uses practice-based solutions, the assessment process has been tested in a pilot project at an important historical and archaeological region with diverse archaeological sites.

Reasons for the assessment

The regional museum of Pest County frequently faced the above-described problems and discrepancies during its field operations. Particularly the regular control of archaeological sites has created growing problems in a period when development-led archaeological programmes occupy most of the working hours of the archaeologists of the museum. Therefore, the museum requested aid in 2021 from the Community Archaeology Association in regularly monitoring archaeological sites. This also offered an opportunity to invite volunteers of the association to take part and to contribute to heritage protection in a meaningful way. Furthermore, members of the association were able to develop their skills in

detecting, surveying, and interpreting archaeological sites with the guidance of expert archaeologists. A survey was thus realised in 2022 within the frames of an experimental community archaeology programme with volunteers and students. The project provided an excellent opportunity to classify the sites under supervision and draw methodological conclusions on the assessment process.

The starting point was a programme of ten field events to research archaeological sites (with outstanding or enhanced significance) under special protection in Pest County using modern site diagnostics methods. The programme focused on surveying the condition of the sites, concentrating mainly on gathering data on already known archaeological sites, rather than discovering new ones. The work was a collaboration between the Cultural Heritage Studies Programme of the Central European University (CEU, Budapest-Vienna), archaeologists from the Ferenczy Museum Centre of Pest County (Szentendre) and a research project by the Community Archaeology Association. Representatives of the authority also participated in several field events.

Location and surroundings

In the frame of this experimental community archaeology programme, the Pilis Mountains and the Szentendre Island was chosen for multiple reasons: these regions are easy to access from Budapest, which was important as most participants lived in the capital or close to these areas. Furthermore, the region played a key role in various historical periods. Important fortified prehistoric hilltop sites can be found in the inner area of the Pilis Mountains, with long research history on their archaeological heritage. In Roman times, the construction of the Danubian Limes, a defensive system along the river, brought about the emergence of a chain of fortifications (burgi and castra). During the Middle Ages, the region became part of the Medium Regni, the central and most developed area of medieval Hungary that comprised four of the five royal seats. The exceptional settlement network that had emerged in the area included clusters of administrative seats, monasteries, and royal estates. The region is rich in archaeological sites of different periods, preserved in various conditions and subject to archaeological fieldwork for a long time, but with significant potential for further research. During the field trips 21 archaeological sites were surveyed, 11

Figure 43: Archaeological fieldwork and metal detector-aided survey at Pomáz, Kő-hill. On-site introduction of the archaeological site for the participants of the project. (Rácz, T.)